

Two Page Sizes, One Discipline

A Comparative Analysis

Supplementary Reading, Session 05: Building the Grid · Portfolio as Narrative

I. Purpose

This reading serves two functions. The first is to consolidate, in written form and without the pace of a live demonstration, the grid system established in Session 05: a document measuring six hundred by eight hundred forty points, built from a twelve-point atomic unit. The second is to introduce a second page size, six hundred twelve by seven hundred ninety-two points, corresponding to standard Letter paper, and to examine what each option offers and what each requires in exchange. The two systems are not a correct answer and an inferior alternative. They represent two different sets of priorities, and the appropriate choice depends on what a given project must do once it leaves this class.

II. Review: The System Established in Session 05

Every measurement in a modular grid derives from a single governing value, the atomic unit. The atomic unit for this class is twelve points, chosen because it divides evenly by two, three, four, and six, and because it accommodates a body text size in the range of nine and one half to ten points, generally treated as optimal for extended reading. This value must be fixed before any other decision, including the size of the document itself, because a modular grid, unlike a column grid, offers no room to improvise the vertical measure after the fact.

With the leading fixed, the document was sized as a whole multiple of it: six hundred points wide by eight hundred forty points tall. The arithmetic is exact. Eight hundred forty divided by twelve equals seventy, with no remainder, meaning the full page height resolves to seventy discrete twelve-point increments before a single margin or column is drawn.

Margins were set to thirty-six points on the top, inside, and outside edges, and forty-eight points on the bottom, equal to three and four multiples of twelve respectively. Removing these margins from the page height leaves seven hundred fifty-six points of content height, which divides by twelve to produce sixty-three whole baseline lines, again with no remainder. Those sixty-three lines were distributed across eight rows: seven lines of content per row, plus one line reserved for the gutter between rows, for a total of eight rows multiplied by seven, plus seven gutters multiplied by one, equal to fifty-six plus seven, equal to sixty-three. The fit is exact, not approximate. Six columns were set with a twelve-point gutter, producing modules of eighty points each. The completed grid, forty-eight modules in total, was verified by toggling the baseline grid on and confirming that every row guide coincided with a baseline rule, without exception.

III. An Alternative: The Letter-Size Page

The page size adopted in Session 05 was chosen for the clarity of its arithmetic, not because it corresponds to a sheet of paper that exists outside the software. A second option exists for students who intend to produce a physically printed portfolio: six hundred twelve by seven hundred ninety-two points, the exact dimensions of Letter paper, the size stocked in nearly every printer and copy shop in the United States. This option was introduced in an earlier reading, “The Inch Was Already Twelve,” which demonstrated that an inch is exactly seventy-two points, six multiples of twelve, meaning Letter paper was already speaking this class's unit before the term began. Seven hundred ninety-two divided by twelve equals sixty-six exactly, confirming that the Letter-size page, like the page used in Session 05, resolves cleanly against the twelve-point unit at the level of the page itself.

IV. Where the Two Systems Diverge

The divergence between the two options does not occur at the level of the page. It occurs one level down, at the level of the row. If a student applies the same margins used in Session 05, thirty-six points on three sides and forty-eight on the bottom, to a Letter-size document, the available content height becomes seven hundred eight points rather than seven hundred fifty-six. Divided across eight rows with twelve-point gutters, this produces a row height of seventy-eight points, equivalent to six and one half baseline units. Half of a baseline unit is not a negligible discrepancy. It means that of the seven internal boundaries separating the eight rows, only alternating boundaries land on an actual baseline rule; the remainder fall precisely between two rules, an offset visible to anyone who zooms in and compares a row guide to the baseline grid beneath it.

Two remedies exist. The first is to accept the offset. Text placed within a row and set to align to the baseline grid will still lock to the nearest rule regardless of where the row's own boundary falls, so the offset affects the visual coincidence of guides, not the correctness of typeset text. The second remedy is to adjust the bottom margin from forty-eight points to ninety-six points, leaving the top, inside, and outside margins unchanged at thirty-six. This produces a content height of six hundred sixty points, which divides across eight rows and seven gutters into a row height of exactly seventy-two points, six whole baseline units, restoring full coincidence between every row boundary and the baseline grid without altering the outer page dimensions of six hundred twelve by seven hundred ninety-two points.

V. Comparative Analysis

Criterion	600 x 840pt (Session 05 system)	612 x 792pt (Letter, adjusted margins)
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Page height divisible by 12	Yes, 70 units	Yes, 66 units
Rows divisible by 12 with 36/48/36/36 margins	Yes, 7 units per row	No, 6.5 units per row
Rows divisible by 12 with adjusted margins	Not applicable	Yes, bottom margin at 96pt, 6 units per row
Corresponds to a real paper size	No	Yes, Letter, 8.5 x 11 in
Two facing pages form a standard spread	No	Yes, Tabloid, 17 x 11 in
Setup steps required	Standard	One additional margin adjustment if full alignment is desired
Recommended when	Grid mechanics are the focus and printing is not planned	The final deliverable will be printed or must match a real paper trim

Beyond the measurements themselves, each option carries a less quantifiable cost. The Session 05 system minimizes the risk of arithmetic error: every value divides evenly under the simplest possible setup, with no secondary adjustment required. Its principal limitation is that a file built at this size cannot be sent directly to a printer without first being rescaled, a step that risks disturbing an already finished layout. The Letter-size option avoids that risk entirely, since the file is already the correct output size, but it demands one additional decision, whether to accept a partial offset between the row grid and the baseline grid or to correct it by enlarging the bottom margin, a decision that must be made deliberately rather than by default.

VI. Selecting an Option

Neither system is more advanced than the other, and neither substitutes for understanding the underlying arithmetic. A student who does not intend to print a physical copy of the final portfolio has no obligation to use the Letter-size page; the system built in Session 05 is complete, correct, and sufficient on its own terms. A student who does intend to print should set up the file at six hundred twelve by seven hundred ninety-two points from the outset, using either the accepted offset or the adjusted bottom margin, rather than resizing a finished six hundred by eight hundred forty point file afterward, since resizing after content has been placed risks disturbing alignment that took deliberate effort to establish.

VII. Conclusion

The two page sizes examined in this reading differ in their outer dimensions and, depending on the margins applied, in the precision of their row alignment. They do not differ in the principle that

governs them. Both are built from the same twelve-point atomic unit, and both depend on the same discipline: choose the unit first, verify every subsequent measurement against it by hand, and treat a fractional result not as an acceptable approximation but as a signal that an earlier decision needs to be revisited. The page size is a choice made in service of that discipline. It is not the discipline itself.

References

Portfolio as Narrative, Session 05: Building the Grid, lecture and in-class activity.

“The Inch Was Already Twelve,” Session 05 reading, Portfolio as Narrative.